

Hiring an Engineering Manager

A framework for hiring an EM at a tech company, and an overview of how Facebook, Amazon and Stripe do it.



GERGELY OROSZ

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Question: My team is growing and I report to me. I've never done this before.

Hiring your first engineering manager is a big jump into what interviews you want to conduct, what is the role in your organization? The hiring process, all the way to what happens after.

In this issue we cover:

- **Building a process to hire EMs.** A framework for defining the role, through the interview process, onboarding.
- **Typical processes at Big Tech and startups.** How it's like at larger and at smaller companies, how it's structured at Facebook, Amazon and Google.
- **Templates** you can use as inspiration for defining and documenting an EM hiring process.
- **My take on hiring engineering managers.** How should you design your process?

Everything in this issue is about hiring *frontline* engineering managers who directly manage engineers. Avoid copying the below process when hiring managers-of-managers, because filling those roles is a different beast altogether.



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Hiring Engineering Managers

Most managers I talk with are clueless about how to hire their first manager. Some have more experienced people who can help them with this challenge. Some others work at larger companies where there are “standard” EM-hiring processes they can default to. And there are a select few managers who have a leadership recruiter who helps them, step by step, with this process.

Avoid blindly copying an existing EM hiring process – the sourcing strategy, the interviews, etc – as it’s a sure way to burn yourself. By copy-pasting another process you will not hire for what *you* need. Even if you think you need to hire for that you need to hire for. Instead, take a few questions.



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1. Define the Role

- **Role definition document.** Is there a career ladder for engineering managers in your organization that defines levels, expectations, competencies? If so, you'll have a much easier time going through the hiring exercise, assuming this

document represents the actual setup. However, save for some of the largest tech companies, most employers do not have this document. Perhaps you can start to put one in place?

- **Scope.** What is within the scope of this role, and what is outside it? List all the things you think fall on the plate of the manager, and things that are responsibilities of others.
- **Expectations.** What do you expect from this role? Although it might be clear to you, as someone who worked at the company, you'll be surprised how much an EM role differs between firms. Here are some questions they are expected from the manager:
 - *What does success look like in this role?* This could range from leading a high-performing team of Y people to making sure you like will help you sell the position.
 - *Expectation of being hands-on.* Do they expect code changes, know the ins-and-outs of the system? Are they expected to stay more high-level?
 - *Budget management.* Do they manage expense budgets? Do they set budgets? Do they manage budget management?
 - *Contractor and vendor management.* Do they manage whom they have to manage? Do they manage approval procedures, follow regulations?
- **Coding; yay or nay?** Is coding part of the role? This will impact how you'll do interviews.
 - *If EMs are expected to code,* will they be on the critical path for projects? Or will they take unimportant parts, to stay somewhat hands-off? How many reports should they be limited to? I would not advise having more than five people report to managers who are also expected to code.
 - *If EMs are not expected to code,* will you still want to make coding part of the interview process? If not, in what other ways will you get a sense of whether



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they are being hands-on enough?

- *Be careful of filtering for coding when it's not a requirement for the role.* Adding a coding interview when coding day-to-day is not part of the role, filters out candidates who do not have the additional time to prepare for coding tests, for the sake of passing the interview. Basically, this will make your candidate pool less diverse.
- I typically see smaller companies with smaller teams expecting managers to code day-to-day, while larger organizations sometimes expect EMs to *know* how to code, but have no expectation of them doing so.

- **Career progression.** What does the career progression look like? What are the expectations at that next level? For all levels, that should answer this one.
- **"Meeting" or "exceeding".** What does "meeting" or "exceeding" look like in this role? Can you write a specific example as part of a document, such as a role description?
- **Must / Should / Nice phrasing.** As a hiring manager, I would expect expectations as 3 bullet points of "must", "should", and "nice to have" to get clarity for the role, and the sign-off on the hiring process.
- **The budget.** What will the salary range be? What is the "default offer", and how much salary flexibility does the budget for the role?



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2. The Job Description

Once you are clear what the role looks like, craft a job description to attract candidates with the right qualifications.

- **Balance selling and filtering.** The less known your company is, the more you'll need to sell the role and detail *why* someone should apply. You'll also want to set reasonable expectations on *who* you'd like to apply. Every new expectation reduces the pool of people who will apply, so be careful to not limit it too much.

- **What would *they* get out of the role?** Apart from listing the things you need from them, detail how they would benefit from the role. What support would they get, which initiatives would they help launch?
- **Use inclusive language** in the job description, or risk alienating a group of applicants. Avoid unconscious biases in the description and follow the sensible advice outlined [in this HBR article](#).
- **Consider listing key stakeholders** this EM would work with. Be concrete about whether they would collaborate with Product, Data Science, or a business function, and so on. Even better if you list their future peers. This is a great way to attract top talent.
- **Consider outlining the roadmap** for the first month, the first three months of the role. See [this description](#) by RevenueCat.
- **Take inspiration from other job descriptions** in your competition phrases these roles use. Borrow from those approaches?

Partner with your recruiter in creating the job description, get their feedback and lean on any experience they have.

3. The Interview Process

With expectations and the job description in hand, it's time to start the interview process. How will you assess candidates' progress through?

Having a dedicated recruiter to help with leadership recruitment is a huge advantage, and one I suggest making a case for, if you've not done so. This is especially true if you'll be hiring multiple managers later on. Similar to hiring Staff-and-above engineers, hiring an Engineering Manager typically involves lots of selling, and a tailored process for which an experienced recruiter makes a real difference.

Assuming you have a recruiter who will help you, I suggest working together to craft a plan of how to build up the funnel, and agree on who will filter resumes and do the first



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call with candidates.

Signals you need to gather is the first thing you should define, as interviews will have to cover all of these. Ideally, based on the first two steps, the signals are clear enough already, meaning you can move on to decide at what point in the process you want to gather these.

Process definition and interviews. What set of steps will candidates go through? Which signals shall each interview gather? How long will each interview be? In the next section, I cover the most common interview types that tech companies use. Take inspiration from these.

For a well-calibrated and unbiased process, document each interview step. That document should include a list of suggested questions. If working in a large company, you can approach, so you set the bar similar for its own approach.

Keep in mind the note on coding we discussed: if coding is not part of the role will make you filter out candidates who did not take additional time to prepare. Many tech companies which don't expect coding interviews as part of the process.

Panel. Who is carrying out the interview? Will you do the whole process, or will you rotate people? Get clarity on what signals they need to gather.

The decision. Who makes the decision? Will you do a debrief with all parties involved, or follow another process? Will you wait for multiple candidates to finish the process, or offer the position to the first person who meets the bar?

If you work in a larger company, consider running a process where a skilled facilitator runs the debriefs, one who is experienced with EM hiring. EM hiring is much more nuanced, compared to hiring individual contributors. For example, at Uber, an experienced manager who was also on the loop as a Bar Raiser would run these loops.



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CTO Will Larson writes in detail about the [problem of hiring loops that reject each applicant](#), and shares advice on how to solve this persistent issue.

Define a clear process. Document the interview process, and share it so everyone involved in hiring has clarity on how this works.

If you're creating a process from scratch, consider documenting the process and doing a kickoff with panelists. Aim to have the same panel interview the first set of candidates, then do a debrief on the process, and tweak it based on the feedback.

Consider documenting both the overview and the details. Every interviewer has a document detailing the hiring process documented:



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Stage	Signals	Panel
Pre-screen		
Recruiter Phone Screen	- Screening questions agreed with HM at the initial job brief. - High-level screening: tech/scale/leadership qualities/role and culture fit. - Explain the process - For senior candidates, skip this step, and combine it with the exploratory stage to save time	Recruiter
Exploratory Call	For candidates who are more passive. - Sell the opportunity and get them excited about the company - Light signals - Good time to have them	Sr EM
Screening		
Management Phone Screen	High-level management breadth & depth, clearing the full load	
Technical Screen	Evaluate the candidate's experience in design to be at-par with a Sr	
Onsite		
Leadership & Alignment	Understanding, ownership, Trust building, trust, Handling failures, Resolving conflicts	
Vision & Mission	Selling the vision, Aligning teams, Communication –	
Execution & working with PM	Collaboration, Product Thinking, Project Management	
Team Building	Hiring & lifecycle of people management, People management, Building high-performance teams	EM
Systems Design	The interviewer could go really deep on the candidate's experience to evaluate their involvement, insights and influence on architecture. Alternatively, set a problem to tackle, aligned with the candidate's prior experience (backend/mobile) to get the same signal.	Staff Eng



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An example of documenting the EM hiring process. See the full document [here](#).

You should design a process to detect the signals that *you* want to collect, without unnecessary duplication. For example, in the above case, the loop does not touch on getting signals of writing skills. It also has two interviews that touch on systems design. Perhaps one of them could be removed?

Templates you can use for inspiration:

- [Interview process overview documented](#)
- [The Leadership & Alignment interview process documented](#)

4. Hiring

With the process in place, it's time to execute. Here are a few things you'll need to do:

- **Post the job** to your company's career page.
- **Spread the word about the role.** Use your peers to advertise this position.
- **Referral bonuses.** Does your company reward people to refer members in their network? If not, like this just yet, consider pushing to add referral bonuses when they struggle to hire. People already at the company take additional time to find good candidates.
- **Re-post the job** on job boards that you use and to more specialized job boards.
- **Source directly.** Sourcing means reaching out to qualified candidates, and encouraging them to apply for the position. Big Tech companies employ specialized recruiters called "sourcers," who seek and reach out to potential candidates. Recruiters and hiring managers also often do sourcing. The most popular sourcing tool is LinkedIn, while tools like [AngelList](#), [Gem](#) or [Entelo](#) offer additional reach.
- **Balance recruiters and hiring managers when reaching out.** Sourcing is a time-consuming activity and recruiters taking on this task take the load off hiring managers.



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managers. However, the response rate for messages from recruiters is typically lower than those sent by hiring managers. Decide how much you want or need to get involved in sourcing, depending on your situation and constraints.

- **Track the funnel and act where things are not working.** Work with your recruiter to track the number of inbound applications, those making it through the resume screen, all the way to people making it to onsite. Where are you seeing fewer applicants, or a large drop? If there's too little inbound, debug your sourcing strategy. If it's at a screening step, dig into what might be happening.
- **Check-in regularly on how the process is going.** Get feedback and encourage people to try new things. When I recruited for a position, I tweaked outreach strategies, invested more in feedback which candidates shared with me, and noticed that the process was moving faster than expected.
- **Track the speed of the process** from application to decision. If this is one or two weeks you are moving fast. If candidates who don't want to wait are dropping out, you're risking candidates dropping out.



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5. The Interview Experience

Interviews are a two-way street, and this is true even if you interview the candidate, they are also interviewing you. Stop the process if they gathered enough information to not want to work at your company, or with your team.

Measure the interview experience and give candidates easy ways to give feedback on the process. Most companies which care about candidate experience invite them to give feedback on the process once it has ended, or when they drop out. They usually collect an NPS score, and encourage comments and suggestions from candidates.

Aim to share actionable feedback with candidates who are a “no”, who went through the whole loop. These people have put a lot of time into the process, and the least you can do is help them with some observations and feedback.

Many companies avoid giving feedback for candidates; many in the US cite a fear of being exposed to lawsuits. I've yet to hear of a lawsuit for giving fair feedback that the candidate could use to grow. I have, however, talked with several EMs who were grateful for getting more specific advice on where they could improve, and later recommended the company to their peers to apply to.

The most common way to deliver this feedback is through a call. A call allows the hiring manager to share the feedback, and the candidate can ask clarifying questions, and for the future.

6. Closing

A candidate has gone through all the interviews. Congratulations! However, you still have

A centralized vetting committee approach is common in larger organizations like Google. An organization committee needs to select the best managers. They typically review interview feedback and levelling suggestions.

Though a committee like this can feel like a barrier to permission, organizations put them in place in order to standardize levelling. Hiring managers with less hiring experience could [down-level candidates](#), or up-level them, and both outcomes cause problems later on.

Reference checks are an important step you should consider not skipping with manager candidates. This means asking them for references, then calling up these individuals, and gathering information relevant for the role. How does feedback from references line up with the signals you gathered? Are there any red flags that come up during the conversation?



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A secret many companies have which hire great managers is that they are very good at doing reference checks. They call up references and don't just confirm signals from the interview, but they gather additional context on how to set up the manager for success. They also tend to dig deeper on areas the panel was uncertain about.

A senior director at a company known to do extensive reference checks shared that their success in manager hiring is closely tied to reference checks. Whenever they skipped it, they regretted it. Also, reference checks would sometimes help with hiring because some references would later apply to the company. A lesson to take here; always sell your organization, even when

The biggest downside of reference checks is that they can be uncomfortable, especially if you only share the very end. If you do reference checks, be prepared to offer extended you should not expect to hear from direct reports of the manager.

Clarify who will present your offer, and how is common at larger tech companies? Or when hiring a manager, I am a fan of being present at the offer, feels about the offer, and to understand the candidate's

Candidates negotiating will be common in the [hiring market](#). Here's a few ways you can

- *Prepare for negotiation upfront.* Get clear on sign-on and equity. Especially at large companies, a lot of time can save you time on having to do this last-minute.
- *Get a sense of compensation expectations upfront.* Many resources advise job seekers to not give you any number upfront. However, if you have an idea of what the candidate expects, you can start off with an offer that is in that ballpark, assuming you have the budget.
- *Consider making multiple offers* when you offer equity in a private company. Many startups tend to offer two or three variations of higher base salary, and lower



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equity. This approach often shortens negotiations, while keeping compensation bands in-line.

- *Be aware of the mid-term cost of going outside bands.* The current market has moved 20-30% up, year-on-year. If your company has compensation bands, the chances are that you might need to go outside of these to make a competitive offer. Be aware that you'll need to recalibrate bands later on, to avoid salaries at the same level getting overly out of sync.
- *Does your company have a "no negotiation" strategy on salary?* Several companies introduce a policy of not negotiating salaries to ensure equal pay. If you are in addition, on top of the non-negotiable salaries, do you offer allowances or more holidays? For the exceptions, especially [in a heated market](#)

Using exploding offers – giving a short deadline before the offer expires – is a pressure tactic on candidates. Both myself and managers view this as a bad tactic.

A manager hire is a key position, one which will last for several years. An exploding offer is a last resort in interviews, or lose the current offer. It sends a message that competition has to offer, and also that you are unwilling to give time for a manager to

7. Onboarding

You've hired an engineering manager, they signed and are ready to join. But are you done with hiring?

Many people assume they are. I don't think this is true. What if the manager joins, but then is let go two months later? Is that a successful hire? Hardly.

Your onboarding process is one that can make or break the success of a new manager hire, and one that when done right, can set them up for a long and successful career at



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the company.

We'll go into more detail about onboarding in a future newsletter. However, here are a few things I'd suggest looking into:

- **Onboarding process.** Do you have a well-defined onboarding process for all new joiners, be they engineers or managers? If not, start defining one.
- **Onboarding process for managers.** Do you have a manager-onboarding process that covers all the details EMs care about? From getting to know stakeholders, manager processes like expenses and how to get things done, to how long it took you months to figure out on your own.
- **Connect them with peers and stakeholders.** Consider drafting a list of relevant people for the first month, at month 2, 3, and 4, and making sure they are connected with the right people will have a major impact on the organization.
- **Coding as part of the onboarding process.** Discuss the pros and cons of the codebase as part of onboarding. The biggest pro is getting a sense of how the process works. The biggest cons are that it may lose the respect of their full-time job and they may have to juggle with other responsibilities, unless it's a small team.
- **Setting goals.** Do you set 30-60-90 day goals? If not, why not? This is an underrated practice that sets expectations both ways.
- **Gathering feedback.** Where do you gather feedback on how the onboarding is going? Do you check-in regularly with their stakeholders and team members?
- **How can you tell if the hire is a success?** It's much easier to know when an engineer has onboarded; they are contributing production-grade code regularly. But what about managers? How will you be able to tell that they are onboarded, and are operating at the level they are expected to? Setting clear goals and taking inspiration from the [Checklist for \(New\) Engineering Managers](#) can give more



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clarity both to you and the new manager, of what a successful onboarding looks like.

Typical Tech Interview Processes

Larger Companies

- **Screening**
 - Resume screen
 - Recruiter chat
 - Management basics
 - Technical basics (usually with a manager)
- **Onsite** consists of a variety of interview types. The types that are utilized are between these:
 - Systems design / architecture
 - Coding
 - Team building / day-to-day management
 - Execution
 - Alignment, vision
 - Project management
 - Project retrospective: talking through a project
 - Writing skills
 - Product thinking, or discussion with a PM
 - Hiring manager or bar raiser
 - Culture fit
- **Closing**
 - Reference calls (more common than with individual contributor (IC) positions)
 - Levelling & team matching



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RazorPay EM Kaushik Bhat collected [common engineering leadership interview types](#) he went through when looking for a new position.

Small Companies

The smaller the company or the team, the more lightweight the process for hiring EMs tends to be. For early startups, the process can be as lightweight as this:

- Resume screen
- Chat with founder
- Chat with PM or another stakeholder
- Closing

As a note, some early startups lack the resources to hire contract CTOs or pull in people from the outside.

Big Tech Interview Process

Large tech companies tend to run both technical and management EM hiring processes. They have invested heavily in the process that is fair, results in quality hires, and reduces bias.

Going through a good EM interview process as a manager, as shared by Google engineer, involves half a dozen interviews – including some

“Going through the interviews made me think about engineering management-wise. Technically, it gave me clarity on modern data driven design despite doing it for a while now and it crystallized several concepts. Management-wise, it really made me refine my opinion on what an EM does and how they should do it.

I recommend EMs go through some interviews, for these benefits if nothing else.”



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As inspiration on how you can improve EM interview processes, here are three examples of different hiring processes.

Facebook

Facebook is the most thorough in preparing candidates for interviews. Not only do they send out a very detailed engineering manager interview guide that has video materials as well, they also do thorough preparation calls with EM candidates.

In the preparation materials, they share Facebook's Seven Manager Behaviours to keep in mind when preparing for interviews:

1. **Care.** Show care by understanding experience at Facebook.
2. **Develop and grow.** Support people based on areas of strength and interest.
3. **Clear expectations.** Set clear expectations for the team.
4. **Feedback.** Give clear, actionable feedback.
5. **Remove roadblocks.** Provide the resources to actively remove roadblocks to success.
6. **Accountability.** Hold people and the team accountable.
7. **Recognition.** Recognize people and their contributions.

Their EM process follows like this:

- **Screening**
 - *Recruiter call:* with the recruiter who will be the point of contact for the process.
 - *Initial interview:* with an EM.
- **Onsite**
 - *Career conversation:* topics about significant projects you have worked on to get a feel of your capabilities and how you work on teams and with other



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groups across an organization.

- *Project retrospective*: Using example(s) from your past, discuss the skills needed to deliver a project from start to finish.
- *People management*: your philosophy, process, and strategy around your management experience, as well as how you communicate effectively to your team.
- *Coding*: Solve a basic computer science problem. The problem will cover basics of algorithms, data structures, design patterns, system design, complexity and basic coding.
- *Design (2x)*: testing your abilities in Facebook's environment. Explore trade-offs within a design. Expect a slightly rusty senior engineer level.

Amazon

Amazon refers to engineering managers as "managers". Amazon has a heavy writing culture and writing exercise is part of the interview process.

[Principles](#).

• Screening

- Recruiter call
- Initial interview
- Written exercise: crafting a response to a written interview question. The response is evaluated based on clarity of thought and expression, and organization and structure. A former Amazon manager shared [how the writing sample carries lots of signal](#) for the rest of the interview.

• Onsite interviews

- Team Management
- Program/Product Management
- SDLC / Operational Excellence



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- Architecture & Systems Design
- Problem Solving & Design (logical & maintainable / software / OO design)
- **Advice** that Amazon shares with candidates. Amazon sends out preparation resources for SDM candidates with an overview of the process, and advice. Some of this advice:
 - "Be prepared to share narratives from your experience to highlight your contribution towards project ownership, management and operational excellence."
 - "Be prepared to talk about specific experience. Like how you ensured situations where the launch date was project risks."
 - "Be prepared to talk about data decision-making or how you as a manager made decisions, and make customer decisions, and make customer decisions."
 - "Have anecdotes ready to show stakeholders to create a roadmap for decisions, and make customer decisions, and make customer decisions."
 - "Have anecdotes ready from your experience to highlight the competencies of a people manager."
 - "Be able to design a system at a high level in specific areas."
 - On the systems design interview, clarification. Your interviewer will intentionally vague to push your innovation."
 - "Keep the customer front of mind. Who is the customer, and what problem are you solving for them?"
 - "Knowledge of distributed systems, SOA, and N-tiered software architecture is very important in answering system design questions. Be sure to review these concepts prior to your interview."



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Big Tech and high-growth startups, from the inside. Highly relevant for software engineers and managers, useful for those working in tech.



Alex Xu is a paid subscriber.

- "Be prepared to talk about operational health, ticket handling, dealing with high severity incidents in the systems you own."

Stripe

Before the onsite, Stripe briefs candidates about the onsite interviews structure, and sends out a preparation document. The roleplay interview is unique to Stripe and they are finding success with this format.

- **Screening**

- Recruiter call
- Experience, Goals and Your Role
- Strategy and Execution

- **Onsite**

- *Technical Discussion:* choose a topic and discuss the technical side with the interviewer.
- *Roleplays:* a 1:1s scenario where candidates discuss challenges are work challenges and how they would solve them in debates.
- *Technical Design Challenge:* design a system or a collaboration tool. Similar to system design.
- *Other: Impact, Fit, People:* diving into the candidate's impact and management experience. The interviewer asks questions like: *What are your ambitious goals, how you recruit and manage technical depth.*



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- *Stripe fit:* Stripe touches on culture fit. They provide the following guidance: "Are you actively inclusive and supportive of individuals whom you work with? Will you fight against other competing forces on behalf of our users? Do you take pride in what you've done, but focus on what you can improve? Do you move with urgency and focus, without thinking the grunt work is beneath you? Do you reason from first principles to get to the right conclusion?"

Takeaways

We've covered crafting a hiring process for engineering managers, and walked through typical hiring processes, as well as those of a few well-known companies.

How should you go about hiring EMs? Here are some thoughts to take with you:

- **It's very hard to hire good engineering managers**, a lot harder than it is hiring engineers, in my view.
- **EM hiring is less objective and more fraught with biases**, compared to the hiring of engineers. The skills you are looking for are more subjective, like how to code, for example – as with people who would be great on the job.
- **Don't blindly copy a process from other companies**, but instead define your own by defining what *you* expect from the role.
- **Document your process**. You'll find it easier to repeat and easier to scale when you have a clear document when you send it around.
- **You're not done when the EM accepts the offer**. I've seen too many EMs fail at decent onboarding, a manager who doesn't get the team up to speed.
- **Hiring managers-of-managers**– a different challenge to hiring managers. The process for hiring managers is different enough that you need a different loop.



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Do you have advice on hiring EMs? Please drop them in the comments:

Good luck with making that hire, and in perfecting your process for finding the ideal EM!

Thanks to [Evelina](#), [Jacek](#), [Jean](#), [Sarmad](#), [Uma](#), and [Viktor](#) for their input and help with this article.



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**Shane Afsar** Jul 22, 2022

Great article! This makes me want to s
processes across companies. I'd also
shifted their process as a result of the
Manager (and above) hiring processe

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